

HEMANT CHAWLA



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WITH FORMER
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SIBAL (LEFT)**

Looking back at history we find two ways out of crises of national and international scale: Revolution or war, or both. Over and over, this cycle of violence has been repeated. It is up to this generation to break this pattern. The interconnectedness of the world today is not only present in the financial markets that are now collapsing; we are also connected on a human level. In the atmosphere, imbalances of hot and cold cause storms and hurricanes. The greater the imbalance, the greater the amount of energy released. The same is true for society. These massive global inequalities are now colliding with great force. Our old mechanisms and institutions will never be able to cope unless the imbalances can be brought down.

I have seen the importance of finding new frameworks in my political career. When I retired from professional chess in 2005, I had a new priority: to help bring democracy to Russia. In our country today, we aren't fighting to win elections, we are fighting to have them. The idea of our Other Russia coalition, which I formed in 2006, was to bring opposition members together from every ideological faction, the

way many different groups united against Augusto Pinochet in Chile in the late 1980s. We are not only a non-ideological coalition, but we also take those ideas that have created change. Any group battling against a despotic government must look up to Mahatma Gandhi. Our motto is "not one broken window!" We believe Russia has exceeded all limits for violence.

The Putin regime still has many defenders in the west and the media. They often say Russians need a strong leader, that there is something in the "Russian soul" that is not compatible with democracy. Just like the US, Russia will never have a black President! A failure of imagination is a virus that can infect even the greatest minds. I want to ask you all a simple question. Name a major, world-changing invention from the last 30 years. With all the technology around us, it seems we are progressing incrementally, focusing on convenience, not big ideas. This mentality has carried over into politics as well. The idea that we only need to make small changes in our own behaviour and our own policies has been refuted. The financial meltdown, the global reach of terror attacks, these are not incremental crises and they will not be solved by incremental thinking.

We must accept that the status quo is dead and change is inevitable. Time and again we hear, "We don't have all the information, we cannot take action." But there is always more information, so inconvenient decisions can be eternally postponed. Don't hesitate. Make tough choices or they will be made for you. To lead is to decide.

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DISCUSSION

Q. Are you concerned or anxious about what will happen to you when you return to Russia? If not, does that not prove that democracy is working in Russia to an extent?

A. I am not sure I can buy this logic. Yes, Russia is not North Korea, hopefully not yet. But we are definitely worse than, say Venezuela. Modern dictatorships are different because they are not

based on the iron curtain policy. Putin's regime is based on the ability of Russia's ruling elite to keep their money in western banks. I hope that you aren't expecting proof of Putin's evil intentions to destroy democracy with the actual shooting of opposition leaders.

Q. Going by the post-Gorbachev experience, would the move towards democracy hurt Russia?

A. This popular mythology could be refuted by facts from history. Russia's greatest economic success was achieved when the rulers offered democratic realisation. The Gorbachev years were a desperate attempt to save the communist system. One of my friends put it bluntly in 1985, "The slaves couldn't build a powerful, personal computer which is why Russia couldn't stay at par

with the USA."

Q. At this moment the opposition does not have a popular support. Do they need to change?

A. If you believe the opposition is weak, give us a chance to talk and don't hide behind the walls. What we want is a dialogue. Let us open a debate, I am very happy to talk about all the issues raised in this discussion.